

EU MONITOR

European politics. Actually worth knowing.

A fortnightly European politics briefing for people under 30 —
built on a monitoring system that watches the EU institutions so nobody has to.

Concept deck
2026

**The EU publishes everything.
Almost none of it reaches anyone.**

Nobody has time to find out which is which — so most people under 30 simply do not follow European politics at all, and then find out about it when it has already happened to them.

2

A fortnightly briefing that finds the five things that actually matter — and explains why.

01 The code watches Europe.

Fifteen institutional feeds, continuously, in the background.

02 I decide what matters.

A human reads the flags and cuts twenty items down to five.

03 Substack explains it.

Ten minutes, every fortnight, with the primary source on every claim.

04 Instagram makes it accessible.

The same research, cut for a scroll rather than a sit-down.

What you come back to after two weeks.

The monitor runs on GitHub Actions on the 1st and 15th, with a source health check every Monday. It fetches, parses, drops what it has already seen, scores what is left, and writes a digest.

It reports how many sources are stale as prominently as it reports what it found — because a rotted source list and a quiet fortnight in Brussels look identical from the digest.

STANDARD-LIBRARY PYTHON · NO DEPENDENCIES · NO API KEYS

EU MONITOR

AUTOMATED RUN · 27 AUG 2026 07:00 UTC · GITHUB ACTIONS

WINDOW13 Aug 2026 → 27 Aug 2026

SOURCES14/15 returned a feed

STALE4 (Commission, EP x2, Council)

FAILED1 (EEAS – returned HTML, not a feed)

NEW SINCElast run, after dedupe: 212 items

NOISE FILTERkilled 74 (advisories, diaries, travel)

37DEVELOPMENTS DETECTED

12POTENTIALLY SIGNIFICANT

7WORTH INVESTIGATING

? SELECTED FOR PUBLICATION – YOUR CALL

SOURCE HEALTH

4 of 15 sources are stale. They parse cleanly and report items, but their newest item is older than the 14-day window. A quiet fortnight in Brussels and a rotted source list look identical from the digest. Read this table before you conclude it was quiet.

SOURCE	TIER	STATUS	ITEMS	NEWEST	AGE
European Commission – press corner	1	STALE	60	28 Jul	30d
European Parliament – press releases	1	STALE	25	12 Jun	76d
European Parliament – committees	1	STALE	20	16 Jun	72d
Council of the EU – press releases	1	STALE	20	15 Jun	73d
EUR-Lex – Commission proposals	1	ok	100	17 Aug	10d
EUR-Lex – Court of Justice case-law	1	ok	100	24 Aug	3d
European Central Bank – press	1	ok	15	26 Aug	1d
gov.uk – news and communications	1	ok	40	27 Aug	0d
EEAS – press	2	FAILED – returned HTML, not a feed	0	–	–

Two questions, asked independently.

Most keyword monitors ask one: is this about my topic? That surfaces everything the Commission publishes about digital policy — forty items a fortnight, and useless.

This asks what a development is about and, separately, why it might matter. The second answer is printed next to every flag, so the review list explains itself.

8 BEATS · 11 SIGNALS · 607 WEIGHTED KEYWORDS

EU MONITOR

RULES.JSON · THE PRIORITISATION MODEL

Two questions, asked independently.

Most keyword monitors ask one: *is this about my topic?* That surfaces everything the Commission publishes about digital policy — roughly forty items a fortnight, and useless.

AXIS 1 – BEAT · 8 CATEGORIES, 323 WEIGHTED KEYWORDS

What is this about?

Power and democracy

War and security

Tech and online life

Climate and energy

Borders and moving around

Money and work

Rights and courts

The UK and Europe

Decides where it lands in the digest.

AXIS 2 – SIGNALS · 11 REASONS, 284 WEIGHTED KEYWORDS

Why might it matter?

Genuinely new

Decision taken

Unusual or unexpected

Likely to generate debate

Consequential

Relevant to young Europeans ×4

UK-EU relevance

Geopolitically important

Economically significant

Technologically significant

Socially relevant

Decides whether it is flagged at all — and prints the reason next to it.

score = min(beat weight, 30) + ∑ signal weight × min(intensity, cap) + tier-1 bonus

Breadth beats repetition.

Each signal's contribution is capped, so an item tripping four different signals outranks one that uses six words from a single signal's list.

Four independent reasons to care is a better story than one reason stated loudly.

7

④ WORTH INVESTIGATING

score ≥ 55 · ≥ 3 signals

AND one of:

youth / unusual / decided / consequential / uk

12

④ POTENTIALLY SIGNIFICANT

score ≥ 25 · ≥ 2 signals

Scan. Promote anything the top tier missed.

37

④ ALSO DETECTED

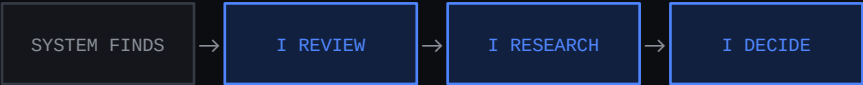
cleared the noise filter

Skim headlines only.

Never write these up.

The most opinionated line in the config is the *requires_any* gate on the top tier. A development can be geopolitically enormous and still be the fourth Ukraine statement that fortnight. Requiring one signal that makes it worth a young reader's ten minutes is what stops the shortlist filling with important things nobody needs to read.

Automation does not replace editorial judgement.



The machine says "this looks potentially significant." That is a different sentence from "this is worth your attention", and the difference is the entire value of the project.

Every selected development is researched against its primary source and answered against seven questions:

1. What actually happened?
2. What changed?
3. Why did it happen?
4. Who does it affect?
5. Why should a young person care?
6. What is the wider political significance?
7. What happens next?

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\$ PYTHON3 REVIEW.PY --LIST · DIGEST 2026-08-27

④ WORTH INVESTIGATING — 7

[1] **Court of Justice rules national rent caps compatible with free movement of capital** **103**
RIGHTS AND COURTS · EUR-LEX CASE-LAW · 24 AUG
DECISION TAKEN UNUSUAL DEBATE CONSEQUENTIAL YOUNG EUROPEANS SOCIAL
score

[2] **UK and EU agree youth mobility scheme in principle** **98**
THE UK AND EUROPE · GOV.UK · 24 AUG
DECISION TAKEN UNUSUAL CONSEQUENTIAL YOUNG EUROPEANS UK-EU
score

[3] **Commission proposes first-ever EU rules on age verification for social media** **96**
TECH AND ONLINE LIFE · COMMISSION PRESS CORNER · 21 AUG
GENUINELY NEW UNUSUAL DEBATE CONSEQUENTIAL YOUNG EUROPEANS TECHNOLOGICAL
score

[4] **Erasmus+ facing 12% cut in draft budget, university associations warn** **85**
BORDERS AND MOVING AROUND · EUR-LEX PROPOSALS · 18 AUG
UNUSUAL DEBATE YOUNG EUROPEANS ECONOMIC
score

④ POTENTIALLY SIGNIFICANT — 12 (SCAN ONLY)

[8] **ECB consumer expectations survey: housing costs lead inflation expectations** **44**
MONEY AND WORK · ECB · 21 AUG

[9] **Commission opens consultation on regional State aid guidelines** **31**
MONEY AND WORK · COMMISSION · 21 AUG

```
Selected 5 of 37. Scaffolding edition 007 _  
  
$ python3 review.py --new-edition 7 --select 1,2,3,4,5  
  
editions/007/brief.md          Substack draft, seven questions per item  
editions/007/carousel-01-05-...md one 7-slide Instagram script per development  
editions/007/checklist.md      14-day production checklist  
editions/007/assets/           exported graphics go here
```

Where machine judgement stops and mine begins.

AUTOMATED — RUNS WITHOUT ME

HUMAN — WHERE THE VALUE IS



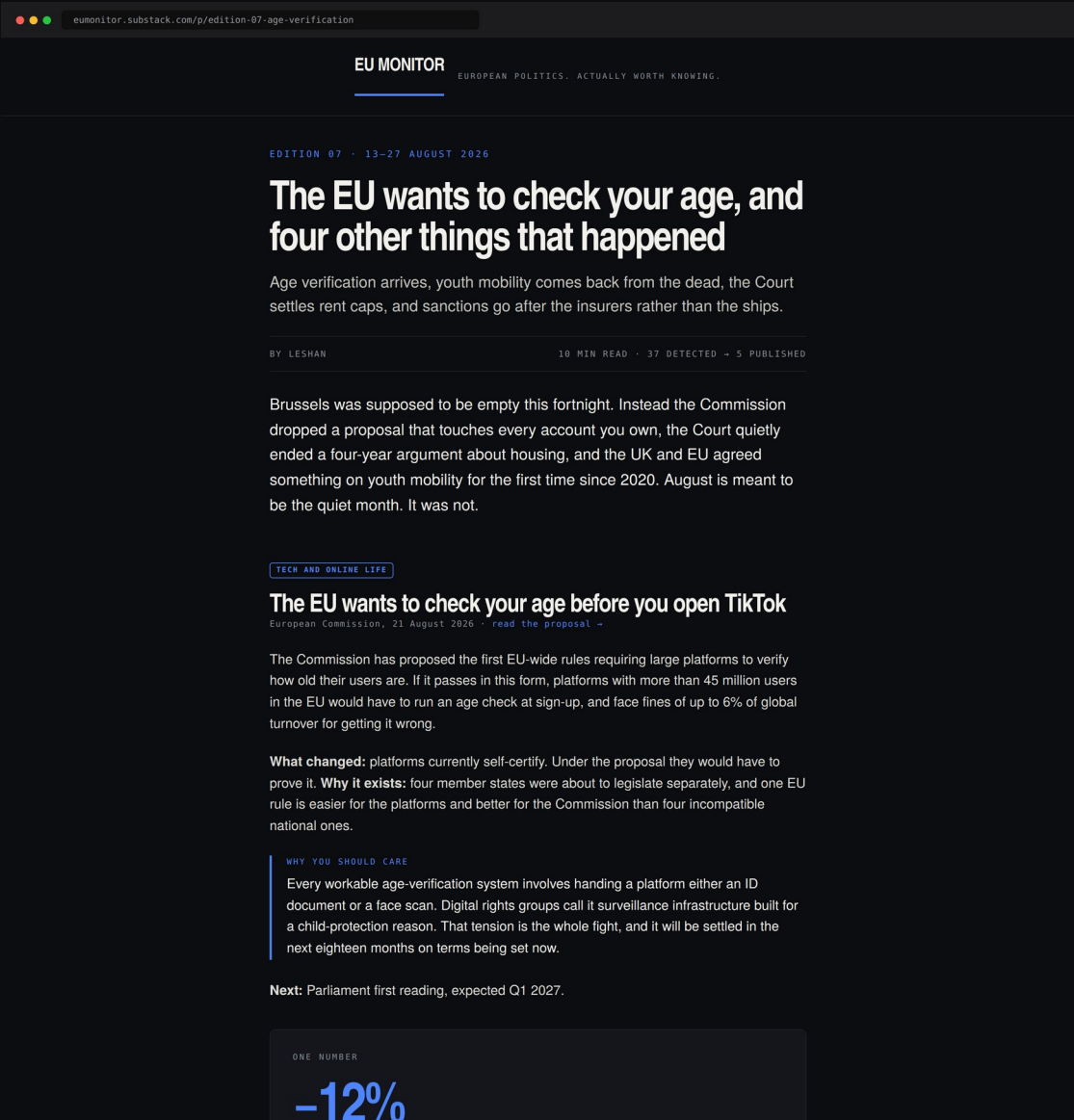
The system produces raw material. It never writes a published word.

Five to eight developments. Ten minutes. Every claim linked to a primary source.

Curation over volume. A reader should finish an edition thinking "I actually understand what has been happening in Europe" — not "I have now read a lot about Europe."

Every item carries a Why you should care panel. One statistic, chart or map per edition. One lighter or genuinely odd European development, because that is what makes people forward the email.

1,200–1,800 WORDS · EVERY OTHER THURSDAY · FREE



Not an advert for the Substack.

If a carousel only says "new edition out now", it has wasted the slot. Each one is worth reading on its own — someone who never opens the Substack should still learn something.

One development → one seven-slide explainer

INSTAGRAM · 1080 × 1350 · EDITION 07

EU MONITOR01/07

TECH AND ONLINE LIFE

The EU wants to check your age before you open TikTok.

Here's what actually happened — and why every account you have is in scope.

SOURCE: EUROPEAN COMMISSION, 21 AUG 2026SWIPE →

01 · HOOK

EU MONITOR02/07

WHAT HAPPENED

The Commission proposed EU-wide age checks for large platforms.

Not a law yet — a proposal. It now goes to Parliament and the Council, which is where it will change.

EUROPEAN COMMISSION · PRESS CORNER21 August 2026

Commission proposes first-ever EU rules on age verification for social media

Applies to platforms with 45m+ EU users. Penalties up to 6% of global turnover.

SOURCE: EUROPEAN COMMISSION, 21 AUG 2026

02 · WHAT HAPPENED

EU MONITOR03/07

WHAT CHANGED

NOW

Platforms tick a box saying they check ages.

↓

PROPOSED

Platforms have to prove it — or pay 6% of global turnover.

That is the entire story. Everything else is detail.

SOURCE: EUROPEAN COMMISSION, 21 AUG 2026

03 · WHAT CHANGED

EU MONITOR06/07

WHY SHOULD YOU CARE

45m

USERS — THE THRESHOLD THAT PUTS A PLATFORM IN SCOPE

Every workable age check means handing a platform an ID document or a face scan. Child protection is the reason. Surveillance infrastructure is the method. That tension is the whole fight, and it gets settled in the next eighteen months.

SOURCE: EUROPEAN COMMISSION, 21 AUG 2026

06 · WHY YOU SHOULD CARE

EU MONITOR07/07

WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

21 AUG 2026 — DONE

Commission publishes the proposal

01 2027

Parliament first reading

LATE 2027

Council position, then trilogue

THE FULL BRIEFING

Five developments, ten minutes, every fortnight. eumonitor.substack.com

EU MONITOR · EDITION 07

07 · WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

Every slide carries one visual device — map, timeline, chart, before/after, comparison, screenshot, or a single large number. A slide of pure body text is the failure mode this format exists to avoid.

EU MONITOR

09

One development. Ninety minutes of research. Four published things.

21 AUG	The Commission proposes EU-wide age checks	Buried in a press-corner feed nobody reads
21 AUG	The system flags it — six signals, score 96	Automatic. Cost: nothing.
DAY 11	I select it, read the proposal, answer seven questions	90 minutes. This is the only expensive step.
DAY 13	Substack: a 180-word briefing with the source linked	Depth, archive, credibility
DAY 13	Instagram: a seven-slide explainer from the same research	Reach, accessibility, no new research
DAY 14	A university EU society reposts it to their members	Distribution I did not have to build

Politically literate, chronically under-served.

18–30

University students, postgraduates, recent graduates and young professionals who follow politics but not EU politics

UK-based, EU-curious

A readership that lost its institutional connection to Europe in 2020 and has had no accessible way back

Already organised

EU, Politics, IR and European societies at every UK university — audiences that already meet, already have feeds, and already need content

DISTRIBUTION — THE UNIVERSITY SOCIETY NETWORK

Cross-posting a carousel

Co-branded explainers

Guest contributions from members

Instagram takeovers

Interviews

Newsletter cross-promotion

Joint events

Sequenced deliberately: publish three editions first, then approach the societies I already work with, then widen. One edition is a pitch. Three is a publication.

Ten days of nothing, four days of work.

Designed to survive a dissertation, a job, and a fortnight when nothing gets done.



9–13.5 hours per edition

Roughly five to seven hours a week, concentrated into a four-day burst. That is the whole argument for fortnightly: it fits inside a fortnight that also contains everything else.

Between too much and too shallow.

TRADITIONAL EU NEWS

**Too much
information.**

Accurate, comprehensive, and written for people whose job it already is. Assumes you know what a trilogue is and why you should care.

SOCIAL MEDIA POLITICS

Often too shallow.

Accessible and fast, but rarely sourced, rarely analytical, and structurally unable to tell you what happens next.

EU MONITOR

**Automated discovery.
Human analysis.
Accessible
presentation.**

A machine reads everything so a person can read the five things that matter — and then explains them to someone who has never read a regulation.

The gap is not information. It is judgement, applied in public, by someone the reader's own age.

The repo is the evidence. The archive is the product.

Public affairs and policy job specs routinely ask for "experience of providing a legislative and policy monitoring service". This is that service — run independently, in public, with the code open and every edition linkable.

Political monitoring

Analysis

Automation

Writing

Social media

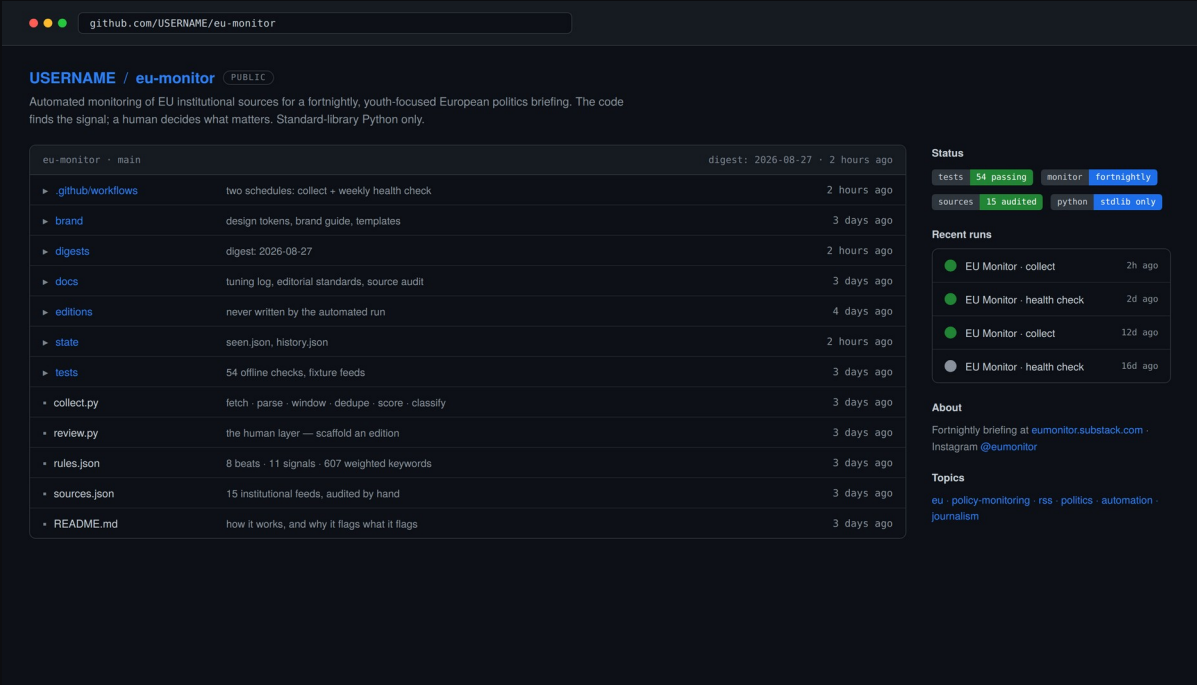
Research

Coding

Data

Visual communication

Stakeholder engagement



54 offline tests · 15 audited sources · 607 weighted keywords · a public tuning log

The ambition

A small, independent European politics publication built for the generation that grew up online.

The code does the boring monitoring. I do the interesting part.

The system finds the signal. I decide what matters.

EU MONITOR
eumonitor.substack.com
@eumonitor